

Rules, Policy & Equity Subcommittee Meeting Notes - March 24, 2021

Member Ruseau, Chair - calls meeting to order - 4:01 PM

Members Graham & McLaughlin - also present

Roll Call - 3-0

Member Ruseau - Boston School Committee issue - Colin and Dave- how are they experiencing

Member McLaughlin - Could you share the Boston School Committee issue?

Member Ruseau - a student member of the school committee resigned, as their experiences were not being valued

Colin - I have the article - he felt he was immediately shut down when questions were asked - I don't feel my comments are overshadowed by not given the same voice as the members have - Idk if Dave feels same way

David - we don't feel we have much of a say being on this board - we are a person on the board to represent the students and to be here to just be here - expand students on board - Fr, Soph, Jr & Sr - come up with proposals for board - with little to no adult supervision, should encompass entire high school - to propose ideas in future

Colin - student representative, Pres and VP of each class who knows each class the most, to get their voices out

Member Ruseau - Pres & VP of the classes? These students are already meeting?

Colin - in the past yes, but not sure this year

Member Ruseau - name for this group?

Colin - Yes, site council

Member McLaughlin - Class officers - that are elected by the class? But I want to think about the students outside of those spaces - how are we incorporating them? I'd like to see a mix

Colin - I agree with that

David - 1-2 people on my proposal - but we can always expand - student elected board - diversity is important - different backgrounds, different walks of life - Medford is divided in a way by class - remove bias of honors and AP's are mostly asians or whites - biggest issue I want to tackle

Member McLaughlin - yes, we should look at that - in curriculum night - it was in the presentations of implicit bias - which I addressed to the principal

Member Graham - connecting to Site Council vs. role you play on school committee? Do you feel there is a need for a better connection or how do these things connect?

Colin - Dave's proposal for 2 student reps per class at SC - Site Council set up is best

David - more student representatives at SC to show representation of school - SC handles budget, but we should have an actual vote on the Board regarding a topic/issue - so students are recorded speaking for their voices

Member McLaughlin - how were selected for the SC?

David - by Principal Fallon - recommended by a teacher or principal - I think they should be elected - 2 seniors - add 2 per year - and later add more over course of 4 years

Member Ruseau - MGL Ch 71, Sec 78- on principle of having a vote on the SC is something that I'd agree with. Unfortunately, the current law is explicit that you can't be voting members and you can't be paid

The way the student reps can be elected via the law

And the law states only one student yet Medford has always had two

I'd like to know, can we have 2? Can the student body elect more than 1?

Being a voting member would have to be changed by Mass State Legislature

I will send you

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - thank you for quoting this law - I appreciate Colin and David's remarks - we are following the law - we have 1 from each side of the house: Comprehensive and Voke - and they could alternate as pre-covid the members were often involved in other groups - when I think about this, I think of this experience as practice for those who would consider becoming elected officials - the SC is the elected officials - you are privy to in your official roles as SC members - maybe have a more active student council - we are following the law - in the newspaper article providing specific opinions and they weren't allowed to speak - I think in Medford, if Colin or David raise their hand, they are asked to speak - harder during covid via zoom, so sometimes not seen - but I don't want either of you to think we don't value you what

you say, or don't want to hear you, because that's not the case - If Colin/David have an issue, maybe contact a particular SC member to work with and they will bring it forward

Member McLaughlin - I think the Boston students had their own group, maybe part of student government - your voices are critical - liaison to the students is a great idea - but maybe liaisons per class or school - many of us have office hours, or we'll meet with any of you for coffee - as we work for you

Member Graham - tactical thoughts - students tend to start later in school year, I think november - maybe need a full year - hold elections that happen either prior year or early in the school year, so you get the full experience - and when we call the Roll, you are added to the Roll, so we know you are there - and make you a co host so you are on the front of the screen - is there a way to call you to vote, but be it non binding - if we did implement this, would you want to vote first or last? You don't have to decide that now - we would redesign the agenda, and have a report from the student rep? Can students submit resolutions? Not sure under the law if that's appropriate

Member Ruseau - well public can submit resolutions in general - so at the same time they should be able to - the liaison or outreach coordinator for SC doesn't need to be us so we could assign an admin or teacher - would you feel comfortable voting, when you can't address it with your fellow students and ask them how they'd like you to vote?

Member McLaughlin - have students have a microphone in chamber if possible, even if handheld - and how are you representing our most marginalized groups - EL, special ed, so they have a voice as well - not sure if this is the law - the voting order - does it say it has to be alphabetical? Just curious about that - we should look at that

Mr. Murphy - I served in this role as a student, and as a SC member, I was the liaison to the students - and have a teacher to work in conjunction as an advisor - identify issues at beginning of year, from student body, what are they wanting to advocate for - in regards to the non-binding vote - there are always issues that students would be voting on that they have no idea about - this is an educational role - I think it's a better practice for students to speak or not on an issue, but not to vote on issues - more appropriate - an opportunity to both lead and to learn - and avoid uncomfortable situations

David - I do feel it's a learning experience but feel they should be able to vote - Yes, No or Abstain - so they should have a non binding vote - I do feel a plan for the year is part of my proposal as well -

Colin - I totally agree with David even if it's non binding - we can decide if we go first or last, but personally I'd like to go first

Member Ruseau - great conversation and this isn't the end of this conversation and invite you to a future meeting

Member McLaughlin - we think about a schedule right now - it would be nice if they could participate before they graduate?

Member Ruseau - so election should be held prior to 1st week of June - to identify this person or persons - and then I'll write up the other items and distribute - but the 3 items in the law, we aren't doing now, we should address immediately - so my hope is we can get a lot done before they graduate

Member Ruseau - Item #2 - Face Coverings - policy sent by MA Assoc of SC

Ms. Wray - it really doesn't require any other information as we follow CDC

Member McLaughlin - I didn't realize MASC brought this forth - it doesn't state anything about disability or an IEP

Ms. Wray - it is the state mandate - a doctor would have to write a note for an exemption - it's written very narrowly - and we have followed this in all of our schools - MASC language

Member McLaughlin - so let MASC know if we have language issues

Member Ruseau - this is a starter kit - we can use our own language preferences

Member McLaughlin - we include

If a student has a disability or on an IEP can't wear a mask - with a doctor note - that precludes them from wearing a mask

Member Ruseau - the IEP part of the language can muddle this a bit - plenty of people with physical disabilities, may not have an IEP at all - anxiety issues - so would you find some language to utilize as we are in a time crunch

Member McLaughlin - yes, I'll work on with the Director of Pupil Services - and we can come up with more appropriate wording

Ms. Wray - the school nurses have assisted and encouraged students to wear masks - we are addressing the needs of all of our students

Member Ruseau - review frequency - we should review this again in September

David - Member McLaughlin's language suggestion is appropriate

Motion to approve this the SC as a whole - 3-0

New policy is passed and to be placed on April 12th agenda

Member McLaughlin - motion to adjourn

Roll Call - 3-0 - meeting is adjourned - 5:01 PM